

Peaky Blinders

(Series 1, Episode 1)

AS Component 2: Investigating media forms and products

A Level Component 2: Media forms and products in depth

Focus areas:

- Media language
- Representation
- Media industries
- Audiences

PRODUCT CONTEXT

- *Peaky Blinders* is a **hybrid-genre, long form TV drama** that combines gangster, Western and historical drama elements. The set product is the first episode of season 1, broadcast in September 2013 on BBC Two in the UK.
- *Peaky Blinders* was produced in the UK by Caryn Mandabach Productions and Tiger Aspect for BBC Two. The show ran for six seasons from 2013 to 2022. For seasons 5 and 6, the show moved to a primetime slot on BBC One.
- The '**showrunner**' for all six seasons was Steven Knight, an established screenwriter and TV producer.
- The plot of *Peaky Blinders* focuses on the Shelby family, who run the eponymous criminal gang in 1920s Birmingham. The first seasons examine the effects of WWI on the working classes, while later seasons portray Tommy Shelby's attempts to move from crime into legitimate businesses, and then onto politics.
- *Peaky Blinders* has won a host of awards, including – for season 1 – Best Director at the BAFTAs, and numerous awards for lighting,

set and costume design. It has also attracted big name actors like Tom Hardy and Adrien Brody.

- In the USA, the show was first distributed by the Weinstein Company and Endemol; it was purchased by Netflix in 2014, who also distributed it worldwide, leading to a global audience.

PART 1: STARTING POINTS – Media language

Consider the codes and conventions of media forms and products, including the processes through which media language develops as a genre:

Genres are 'types' of media product that present **codes and conventions** in a way that provides very specific **audience pleasures**. They are favoured by producers and institutions as they often represent a risk-free investment. Audiences' (and creators') relationship with genres is complex, involving a balance between familiar tropes and fresh elements that enable genres to evolve.

- *Peaky Blinders* could be classed as a **cross-genre** or **hybrid** long form television drama. It has many characteristics of the gangster subgenre. This differs from other crime genres; in that it often focuses on the personal lives of a criminal family. *Peaky Blinders* could also be classed as **historical drama** – it uses lavish production design to evoke a specific period and location concentrating on Birmingham in 1919. It also explores many of the social and political issues of that time.
- *Peaky Blinder's* creator and chief writer, Steven Knight, has also said each season is based around another movie genre. In season 1, he said he was particularly inspired by the Western.